

# Etching A Sketch

I've been fascinated by the graphics tablet that the designers use here. Even as I watched them sketching and drawing, I wondered if their ease arose from constant use of the instrument or if the gadget was just plain easy to use. Did it feel very different from sketching using a pencil?

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**My efforts with a pencil...**



**My masterpiece using the graphics tablet**

1

It's an unwritten law that if a hand-sketched image is to be scanned, it better be worthy of veneration! My initial attempts at drawing drew sniggers from colleagues. I should not have been surprised—it's been ages since I wrote with a pen. The memory of a pencil is even further off. Although I knew the rudiments of drawing, it had been too long ago. So I decided to do myself a favour...

At the designers' corner, Pradeep, one of our designers, showed me how to use the Graphire graphics tablet. It looked like a high-tech slate; I spent some time doodling on the PC. After a five-minute exercise with the tool, I realised that using it would be much tougher for someone not accomplished with a pencil. You don't have to be really good at drawing, but a deft hand is a definite requirement.

2

A three-hour, four-day summer course promised improvement in my sketching and drawing skills. At the end of my sessions, I did find my "art" markedly improved. I put in a lot of hard work, and then, soon enough, I was ready to scan it! The imperfections seemed more obvious on the screen, but anyway...

For my drawing, I chose an action figure—an object that, I discovered, was challenging enough. Working on a tablet makes things easy—a wrong stroke can just be undone! Besides, for symmetry, I could always invert an image to create an exact match. Satisfied with what I had sketched, I tried my hand at colouring it.

3

Working with colour was next. I couldn't colour the earlier image—it was replete with pencil shading. I made another drawing, and used pastels for the colour. I had to be careful because every wrong stroke required a bit of covering up.

Colouring an image on the screen is much, much easier than with pencil and paper. I can create a layer for my original sketch and colour on the layer, akin to placing a tracing sheet on paper and then colouring the tracing sheet. And I found that I could create as many layers as I wanted. Cool!

4

I finally finished the second piece too. The whole cause cost me more time than I expected to spend, courtesy my rather average drawing skills, but my efforts have a proud place on the *Digit* pin-up board, not to mention on our backup server!

I found that I was done a lot faster with the graphics tablet, and because I could undo, I had a much more professional looking drawing. The colouring, thanks to my experimentation with layers, was really good too.

Fun Quotient: **3/5**  
Total Time Taken: **1.5 + 1.5 = 3 Hours**



Fun Quotient: **4/5**  
Total Time Taken: **1 hour 45 mins**



AND  
THE  
WINNER  
IS...

**G**ood old sketching is fun, but if you want to save on time and need a record of all you sketch, draw and colour, the tech way is the only way. A graphics tablet is easy to use, and if you're adept at Photoshop, the PC is really neat. But the use of the tablet assumes a

reasonably deft hand. Although you can conceivably scan an image into Photoshop and then work on it, it's not entirely feasible. For ease, its technology. For practice and developing your art, it's definitely pencil and paper.